a time when Myanmar's newly elected leaders are seeking to find better mechanisms for resolving old grievances. Aung San Suu Kyi talks of a twenty-first century Panglong Conference that draws its strength from the 1947 deal between her father, General Aung San, and the leaders of three major ethnic minorities. With this in mind, an historical sensibility is the basic foundation for any serious consideration of conflict in Myanmar today. As a response to contemporary conflict situations, this volume is structured around three key themes: war, politics and religion. To help introduce the volume, this chapter explains the historical and political context for each of these issues, starting with war.

WAR

In Myanmar, like in other countries defined by civil conflict, families and communities have been torn apart by their divided loyalties. These battles go back to the 1940s when, in the aftermath of the Second World War, the central government struggled to control secessionists at the margins (Smith 2007). Battles over political ideology and ethnic identity eventually left vast areas of the country relatively ungoverned, with Tatmadaw units bunkered down in well-fortified garrisons. In the early years of conflict, the consequences for local people varied immensely, with many welcoming the fresh ambition of communist or ethnic armies that operated in their areas. Through the 1960s and 1970s, under the socialist government of General Ne Win, conflict shaped all aspects of life, especially in the ethnic majority States (see Nakanishi 2013). Rebels established fixed bases and exerted influence over large proportions of the country. It was only in the late 1980s that the Communist Party of Burma imploded, splintering into ethnic militias, such as the powerful United Wa State Army (UWSA). Some of these groups agreed to ceasefires with the central government, which, after its own change of top-level leadership, was enthusiastic about a self-proclaimed mission to restore "law and order".

The 1990s then witnessed erratic progress towards what the military government described as "peace and development". Some of the ceasefires, like the one agreed with the Kachin Independence Army (KIA) in 1993, benefited from sophisticated local deal-making that enriched Myanmar military commanders and their counterparts in ethnic military, political and business groups (see Farrelly 2012b). Consolidating these agreements